

You're cozying up on your couch, walking from Point A to Point B, or procrastinating on work. Per usual, you opt to open up TikTok, and when you do — swiping from video to video, jumping from creator to creator — a variety of fashion trends flood the For You page. Variations of low-rise pants, butterfly clips, “brownie-glazed lips,” and tracksuits, among others, have skyrocketed in popularity in recent years, and it's difficult to not come across them both in-person and online. As you scroll from one seemingly harmless fashion video to the next video that the TikTok algorithm has recommended you, you suddenly see a frustrated Latina creator speak about Hailey Bieber's trending lip combination — dubbed as “brownie-glazed lips” — which has been taking the fashion community by storm.

“Really, a ‘brownie-glazed lip?’ So I’m called ghetto when I do it, but when a white girl does it, she’s not?” [@addison024](#) on TikTok said.

Since the TikTok video gained national attention, and even before, users of the social media app and celebrities have started to call out their peers for cultural appropriation and the lack of acknowledgment or credit to where these looks originated from, specifically to Latinx and Black women. Cultural appropriation, as defined by Oxford Languages, is “the unacknowledged or inappropriate adoption of the customs, practices, ideas, etc. of one people or society by members of another and typically more dominant people or society.” Cultural appropriation is not a minor concept. In fact, a [YPulse survey](#) shows that 64% of young people agree that cultural appropriation is a problem in the United States. Still, despite this agreement on this issue, a significant change has yet to occur.

Presently, trends that are going around include the [“Y2K” filter](#) that places Chola makeup on the faces of white women, the trending [“spa water”](#) recipe that replicates agua frescas, and the use of brown lip liner and lipstick, which has been used for decades among the women of color (WOC) community. These signature looks have been around long before mainstream media and the more famous, and oftentimes white, influencers decided to replicate the look and claim it as their own. Though these trends are seen as new and upcoming for younger audiences, once they are “recreated” by an influencer, there has been an uproar in public reaction on whether this is cultural appropriation or not, and if credit should be given. “I think it would definitely decrease the backlash if credit was given, but I don't think that solves the issue,” Kate*, a second-year female UC Santa Barbara student, stated.

Not only should credit be given to the cultures who influenced the looks, but these videos also touch on the issue that as soon as a white female does the look, it becomes a trend and is highly sought after. Many are aware of this, including those involved in the beauty and fashion sphere of social media, such as Sydney*, a white, female TikTok influencer with 150k followers. “I totally understand the frustration because as soon as a white famous model does it, then it's trendy all of a sudden,” she said.

The issue with this current subject, however, is how deep-rooted it is in history and how relatively novel the conversation surrounding it finds itself to be. Cultural appropriation is not a new, untangled problem that can be solved through a few videos — it's a complex symptom of perpetual racism and institutionalized white supremacy.

In today's technologically dependent society, social media has undeniably become a crucial contributor to fashion. On platforms such as Instagram, Pinterest, and TikTok, just to name a few, fashion tips and outfit inspiration content are being circulated at a rapid pace, easily accessible to any and all. In the last couple of years, there has been a noticeable increase in fashion trends inspired by past decades evident in social media posts and in-person: the hair scrunchy from the '80s, the grunge and hip-hop style of the '90s, and the current reemergence of Y2K styles, including "low rise pants, butterfly clips, longer shirts ... just those types of 2000s trends that people wore," according to Kate.

In fact, social media has been predominantly influential for younger generations who grow up with its presence. Based on what current influencers are doing or wearing in their content, children, teens, and young adults figure out their personal style, their personality, and even what is "right" or "wrong." Anyone, from the Baby Boomer Generation to Generation Z, can utilize the platforms to keep up with current style trends set by their favorite designers or content creators — or to unintentionally imitate people of color (POC) culture without fully understanding the significance of their actions.

Due to the disorganized and fast-paced traffic by which social media and its users operate, information is lost or cut out and credit is not given where it's due. On TikTok, with its mass population of users and short 15-second to one-minute videos, creators often neglect to consider and include the origins of the fashion trend they are promoting, whether or not they, or another, "created" it. Oftentimes, these trends are already practiced in POC communities, and their being credited to white creators in the mainstream media is disrespectful and disregards those heritages. In regards to fashion, a byproduct of culture that is often dependent on global exploration, there is no problem in taking inspiration from different cultures, as long as the taker is doing so in a respectful manner, is crediting accordingly, and has an understanding of the historical significance for that culture. Nonetheless, there is a fine line between appropriation and appreciation in fashion creativity, and TikTok influencers are not the first to cross that line. Prominent fashion houses such as Carolina Herrera and Gucci have ignored that line, selling [traditional Saltillo shawls](#) and a ["balaclava" turtleneck sweater](#) that mimics blackface, respectively. The Gucci Fall/Winter 2018 collection that debuted the sweater faced great backlash due to the piece's strong resemblance to blackface, as the sweater's turtleneck expands past the neck to cover half of the face with an enlarged cut-out mouth with large red lips.

The public called the brand out immediately and did not hold back. One Twitter user [wrote](#), “someone obviously didn’t let gucci know it’s Black HISTORY Month and NOT BLACKFACE Month.” Although the company released multiple statements apologizing for their thoughtless, controversial product, and took the sweater down from their website, this incident brought to light how deeply embedded racism and white supremacy are in the fashion industry. This demonstrated to society how fashion brands are not ethnically responsible and inclusive with their designs. Although people were audibly upset at Gucci for this product release and insensitivity, the social media uproar quickly settled down and the brand did not face major repercussions after removing the product.

Such large and influential names that are at the forefront of fashion and innovation should not be making these mistakes as it tells audiences that what they are doing is acceptable, thus perpetuating the serious repercussions of social inequality, injustice, and racism.

Especially on casual media platforms, when certain fashion trends are called out for cultural appropriation, there is often a significant lack of consequence for those creators. One of the recent examples of this is [Hailey Bieber’s fall lip combination](#) that blew up on TikTok earlier this with 26.3 million views.

“I think the brown lip liner trend is super controversial right now. I keep seeing TikTok videos about girls being upset about this because a lot of POC or women of color have been doing this for a while, but it only became a trend when Hailey Bieber did it,” Kate said.

The top comments on the celebrity’s video sarcastically call her out for taking a beauty technique that has been prevalent for decades in Black and Latinx communities and remarketing it for white audiences as “brownie-glazed lips” in her next [video](#).

“Old School POC lip combo. Been doing it since 90’s,” TikTok user [@shorty7771](#) commented.

“brownie glazed lips? As a Latina I am used to it being referred as ‘tomar de la Olla de frijol’ well, she is bringing back something that never left,” another TikTok user [@alezza12](#) commented.

While numerous POC users on the platform have [pointed out](#) the appropriation that is a money-maker for Bieber, Bieber has yet to acknowledge or credit the POC communities. And others stand by Bieber’s actions.

Although Kate believes that giving due credit can alleviate the backlash of cultural appropriation, white, fourth-year UCSB student Emma* is against giving credit when it comes to trends.

“I think everyone needs to stop being so sensitive ... I think people should be flattered if white people are taking from their culture, rather than being offended and in a way trying to ‘gatekeep.’”

It can also be noted that, just two months later, this instance of cultural appropriation, similar to those preceding it, has blown over quickly without anything changing. Essentially, POC creators are being silenced when they call out cultural appropriation, and a large cause of that is the lack of diversity on social media platforms, from Eurocentric-gear face and beauty filters and algorithms for sorting through content to recommend users. It’s almost as if social media normalizes cultural appropriation.

It is no secret that social media’s use of filters across several platforms has emerged as a national phenomenon – Snapchat, Instagram, TikTok, and more have implemented their renditions of the aforementioned. Specifically, Snapchat reported that upwards of 200 million individuals use their filter product, Lenses, on a daily basis, showing its prominence. Despite the lightheartedness and fun of these filters, Lenses, along with comparable filters among other forms of social media, have received substantial backlash for their implicit racial bias. This message was echoed by a female participant in a Consumer Reports survey who requested to remain anonymous, as she stated “Many of the [beauty filters are designed with Eurocentric features](#). This is problematic for people of color and their personal image.” The repercussions of Eurocentrism on social media are seen in several beauty industries – namely in fashion, skin-lightening, and more; a Massachusetts Institute of Technology Technology Review article discussing the perpetuation of colorism in beauty filters revealed that the skin-lightening industry is now worth more than [\\$8 billion worldwide annually](#). Thus, it is evident that beauty filters across all social media platforms are embedded with racial bias and trouble users of color. These consequences are further identifiable within other industries, showing their global magnitude and their influence on individuals.

Meanwhile, white, TikTok content creator Charlotte* is diligent with crediting other creators and avoiding prejudiced filters and trends, aware of the young audience that she has influence over. “The majority of my following is younger teenage girls and I take that very seriously; I want to be a good influence and a role model for the younger girls and younger generations. So, by doing a simple and thoughtless trend that could be harmful to women of color or be taken away from their cultural traditions without giving credit, I can totally see how that could be harmful.”

Further, issues of racial bias in social media extend beyond the implementation of filters. TikTok’s notorious algorithm that provides users with content has seen similar controversy for employing a racial bias, as the platform maintains the mission to give its users content they are interested in. Marc Faddoul, an artificial intelligence researcher at the University of California, Berkeley, believes that TikTok’s algorithmic obsession has an unintended consequence. A [Wired](#)

[article](#) titled ‘Why is TikTok Creating Filter Bubbles Based on Your Race’ expresses that “Faddoul found that hitting follow on an Asian man with dyed hair gave him more Asian men with dyed hair, and the same thing happened for men with visible disabilities.” This portrays TikTok’s algorithmic approach to providing its users with content they believe is of their interest.

Despite the mission to provide its users with suitable content, TikTok influencer [Ziggi Tyler has publicly expressed their disapproval](#) of the algorithm from a racial bias perspective. Specifically, it is explained that including the word ‘Black’ resulted in Tyler’s content being deemed inappropriate and flagged on the platform. This was validated on a number of occasions, as Tyler tried a number of phrases, including “Black Lives Matter,” “black people,” “black voices” and “black success,” and simply stating “I am a black man” – all of which immediately triggered a message prompting him to remove any inappropriate content. To assess the algorithm’s racial bias techniques, Tyler also released a Tiktok suggesting controversial phrases such as [“I am a neo Nazi”](#) and [“I am an Anti-Semite”](#) – this video, which has garnered over 1.1 million views since its release date, received no inappropriate flagging and illustrates the algorithmic racial bias present.

Due to the rapid advancement of technology, these features of social media have made Eurocentricity the norm, systematically leading audiences to overlook POC communities. Thus, users, especially young kids where the content they consume has ingrained Eurocentric beauty standards in their heads, grow up with the idea that fashion and media revolve around the white population. This, in turn, perpetuates a lack of thought and consideration for other cultures and ethnicities.

“No, I was not aware of this [trends replicating Latinx and Black women’s cultures], I have definitely seen some of the trends but didn’t stop to think more about it,” Emma stated.

The question now is: What can we do to put an end to this racist, online cycle that fuels social inequality, injustice, and racism?

The answer for such a complex problem that is the cross-section of technology, internet culture, and white supremacy is just as convoluted, with no easy remedy in sight. However, a good start would be for us, as users, to begin educating audiences, the public, and ourselves on how to spot and denounce cultural appropriation.

That and, of course, to credit accordingly are simple first steps to take. Whether it be white creators rebranding Latinx and Black traditions as their own or creators sharing their original idea, credit is, and will always be, appreciated. This is crucial because while some, such as Emma, believe that doing a certain trend “touches on the topic of racism rather than stealing trends from cultures,” the latter is quite synonymous with the former.

Informing audiences about other cultures and having diverse representation on social media can promote the calling out of whitewashing filters and colonizing POC trends — a step towards popping the Eurocentric bubble in which many, especially social media, live in. Even social media influencers, including Charlotte, who stick to unproblematic and simple content in fear of saying the wrong thing or saying something harmful acknowledge that that is not enough.

“I think that is also wrong because I am ignoring the issues at hand when I should be talking about it or educating myself further.”

*Names changed for anonymity.